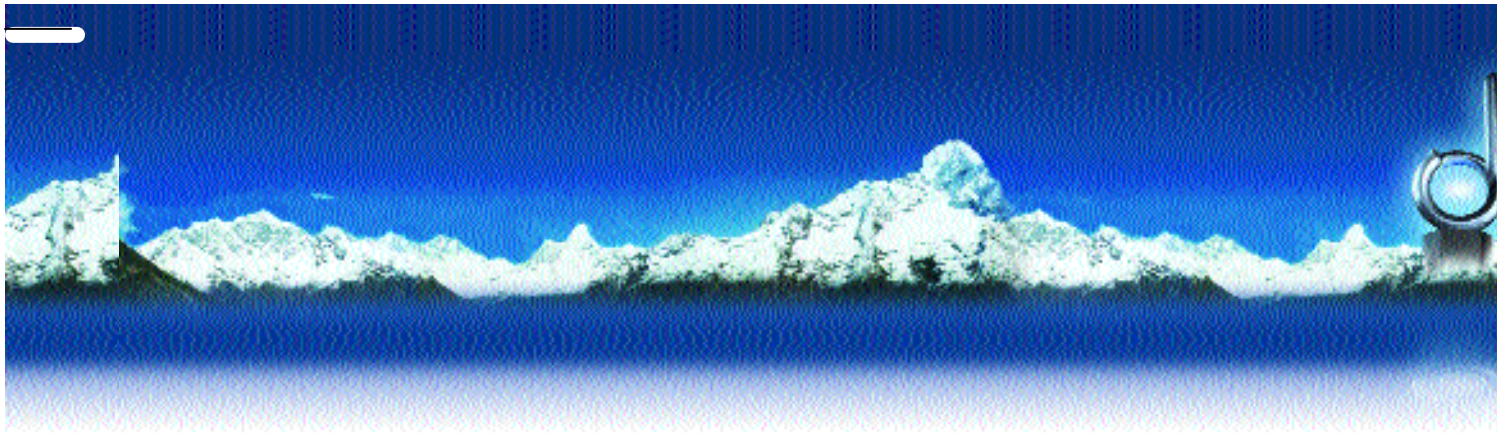
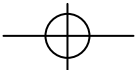




SPEAKERS

Computer speakers used to be humble boxes spreading the sound in a 50 cm radius. Now they've grown into mammoth sound blasters. It all started with the advent of multi-channel audio support on the computer. Ever since the quad channel and 5.1 soundcards hit the scene, manufacturers created speaker systems that were complemented these systems. Thus was born the 4.1 and the 5.1 speaker systems we know today.

Hear the difference

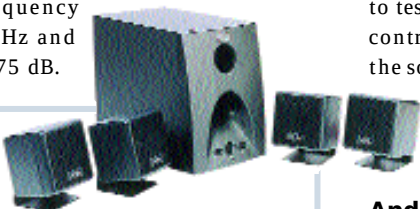
PC speakers are specified by the audio characteristics of frequency response, Total Harmonic Distortion (THD), Sound Pressure Level (SPL) and of course, power rating. However, the specified characteristics often belie the true capability of the speakers. Thus, always judge the speaker quality after you have heard how they sound. Always consider the RMS rating—the PMPO rating, though larger in value, is misleading and should not be relied upon.

In a four-channel speaker system, ensure that the power rating of each satellite and the subwoofer is at least 4 Watts and 15 Watts RMS, respectively. The higher this rating, the greater is the power delivery of your speakers. For THD, the acceptable levels are 0.3 per cent. The frequency response should be between 20 Hz and 20 KHz. SPL should be 75 dB.



Artis S880
(4.1/5.1-channel category)
Kunhar Peripherals Pvt Ltd,
Ph: 022-22345758

The verdict: Though diminutive in size, this quad-channel speaker setup boasts crisp highs and defined bass, making for an excellent speaker system for performance gaming and immersive movies



Consider buying digital speaker systems—these have a decoder that encodes multi-channel encoded sound such as Dolby Digital. These speakers produce the highest sound quality, but you need to have a soundcard that features a digital-out to drive them. At the upper end of the scale, speaker systems feature dedicated multi-channel amplifiers that can decode four-channel and 5.1-channel audio signals from your games and movies, amplify them and send them to the matched speakers. These are ideal for a PC-based home theatre system, where you need power and compliance with multi-channel standards.

Newer breeds of four-channel and 5.1-channel speaker systems have taken audio power levels to new heights with support for industrial-strength audio standards such as THX. These speakers boast of power ratings in the realm of 300 to 500 watts RMS—enough to bring the roof down! Such speakers are best suited to home theatres—there is virtually no difference between watching a DVD movie in your home and in a movie theatre!

Make sure that you hear how the speakers sound with the

Nominees

Name	Contacts	Comments
4.1 and 5.1 SPEAKERS		
Artis X8 5.1	Kunhar Peripherals Pvt Ltd, Ph: 022-22345758	This speaker system boasts of and powerful subwoofer with satellites, making it a very go companion for a 5.1-channel hon system.
Labtec Arena 530	Aditya Infotech Ltd Ph: 022-26338555	This quad-channel speaker sy foms very well, especially wh ducing sound effects and is i ed to movies and really loud
2.1 SPEAKERS		
Artis S320	Kunhar Peripherals Pvt Ltd, Ph: 022-22345758	Boasting of especially good p ance during DVD playback, th system also provided very sha
Labtec Pulse 325	Aditya Infotech Ltd, Ph: 022-26338555	Suited very well for gaming, speakers delivered excellent in reproducing sound effects out impressively even at high

music you specifically listen to—carry a CD of your favour to test the speakers' quality. When testing, set the bass a controls to a mid point and see how loud the speakers g the sound begins to distort. This will help you decide wh 'room-shaking' power of the speaker is actually present or if there's just a tinny cacophony!

And the award goes to...

The 4.1/5.1-channel speaker system that delivered outstanding performance in the categories of gaming as well as



Sumoku Alpha 4R
(2.1-channel category)
Palesha Electronics Industries, Ph: 9520-6355702

The verdict: Sporting a separate amplifier unit cont the controls, this speaker system delivered sound quality and that belied its size



movies was the Artis S880. This speaker system was als handle high volume levels with ease and is therefor suited to users who like to play audio at blaring volun

Among the 2.1 speaker systems, the Sumoku Alpha ered very good response in our tests, especially during I back where the response was very sharp. This was also in its superior treble response.

The speakers have a separate amplifier that contain controls, so they can be placed in a convenient location bothering to keep them within arm's reach. If it's ster that you're looking for, this one offers superior sound c

